What Dad Needs and Who Covers It: A Needs-Versus-Support Worksheet

Line up what Dad needs with the help in place, and mark what you've seen and what you've only been told.

“The aide helps with his shower” is what the plan says. “I was there Wednesday, and she did” is something you saw. Both belong on this page, marked as what they are.

Fill it in over a week, not in one sitting. Start each line with the need, so the sections match up. Where you don't know, write “not sure yet” and leave it. Not sure isn't the same as not happening.

What Dad needs help with, and where you learned it

One need to a line, in plain words. After each, note where it comes from and the date: the care plan, something you saw, something Dad or your sister told you.

FOR EXAMPLE Shower, three mornings a week: care plan, dated August. Supper every evening: Karen told me on the phone last week.

Who covers each one now

The agency, a family member, a neighbor, Dad himself, or no one yet. Write the day and time if you know them.

FOR EXAMPLE Shower: the agency aide, Monday, Wednesday and Friday mornings. Supper: Karen, most evenings after work.

Seen, or only told

Write “seen” where someone in the family watched it happen, and when. Write “told” where you're going on the paperwork or on what someone said. If three of you heard the same thing from one person, that is still one account.

FOR EXAMPLE Shower: seen, I was there Wednesday. Pill reminders: told. It's on the schedule, and nobody in the family has been there for it.

The help that isn't on any schedule

What your sister, or whoever fills in, does for Dad without it being written anywhere. Ask her; she knows more than anyone. Note anything that also appears on the plan as someone else's job.

FOR EXAMPLE Karen: supper, laundry on Saturdays, picks up his prescriptions. Laundry is also listed on the plan for the Wednesday visit.

What's still open

A need with no name beside it, a line you can't confirm, or two accounts that don't match. Write each one as a question, not a complaint.

FOR EXAMPLE Who changes the bed? It isn't on the plan and nobody has mentioned it. Does the Friday visit include lunch?

In Dad's words, and your sister's

How the arrangement feels to the people living it. Write what they say, the way they say it, and keep Dad's account separate from everyone else's.

FOR EXAMPLE Dad: “I like the one who comes Fridays. Mondays I never know who it'll be.” Karen: “I don't mind the suppers. It's the weekends.”

What this shows you

Three things: what Dad needs as far as you can tell, who covers each part, and which lines you've seen for yourself. It doesn't show whether his care is working or whether anything should change. Nothing here adds up to a score, and an open line is a question to ask, not a finding. Questions about his health or his medications go to his doctor or nurse.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what Dad needs, who covers it, and what you've seen for yourself. The care interview picks up from there: it goes through his situation area by area, so the needs nobody thought to list come up too, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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